

Cavylike rodents

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Mammalia
ORDER	Rodentia
SUBORDER	Histricomorpha
FAMILIES	18
SPECIES	301

Included in this “umbrella” group are species as diverse as the semiaquatic capybara, the largest living rodent; the New World porcupines, which are arboreal and possess distinctive spines and a prehensile tail; and African mole-rats, which live underground. The defining feature of the suborder is the organization

of the jaw muscles (see p.116), and most species are characterized by a relatively large head, a sturdy body, a short tail, and slender legs. Cavylike rodents are found throughout Africa, the Americas, and Asia.

SAFETY IN NUMBERS

By living in a family group, these capybaras greatly increase the chances of spotting a predator before it can attack.



Erethizon dorsatum

North American porcupine



Location Canada, USA

Length 23½–51 in
(60–130 cm)

Tail 6½–10 in
(16–25 cm)

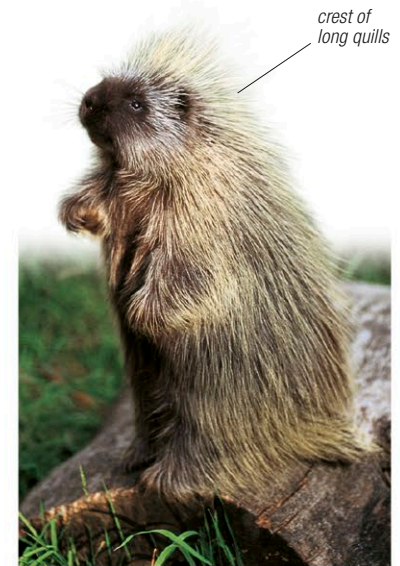
Weight 11–26 lb
(5–12 kg)

Social unit Individual

Status Least concern



The large crest of long quills, up to 3 in (8 cm) long on the head, identifies this stocky, short-limbed porcupine. The strong, broad feet have sharp claws and naked soles, to aid grip. The North American porcupine is very vocal, especially during courtship in early winter, when it whines, screeches, grunts, mews, and hoots.



crest of long quills

QUILLS AND FUR

The main quills are yellow-white, with black or brown tips. The rest of the body is furred and spined in shades of brown.

CLUMSY CLIMBER

The North American porcupine seems clumsy in trees, yet it climbs extensively for buds, blossom, shoots, leaves, berries, and nuts. It also eats grass and farm crops in summer, and soft bark and conifer needles in winter. Solitary most of the year, it does not hibernate and may share a den in cold spells.



Hystrix africae australis

Cape porcupine



Location C. to southern Africa

Length 25–32 in
(63–80 cm)

Tail 4¼–5 in
(10.5–13 cm)

Weight 22–53 lb
(10–24 kg)

Social unit Variable

Status Least concern



These rodents sniff and forage for distances of up to 9 miles (15 km) at night, alone, in pairs, or in small groups, seeking roots, bulbs, berries, and fruit. By day, they rest in caves or rocky crevices. After a gestation period of 93–105 days, the female produces 1–3 young, and the male helps care for them. The Cape (or crested) porcupine communicates by means of quill-rattles, piping squeaks, and grunts.

BARBED DEFENSE



The Cape porcupine cannot shoot out its quills; but, if alarmed, it raises them and charges backward at the enemy. The quills detach easily and their barbed tips work into the aggressor's flesh. These defenses effectively deter attacks by other animals, but these porcupines are killed in large numbers by humans because they damage crops, and for their prized meat.

Coendou prehensilis

Stump-tailed porcupine



Location N. and E. South America, Trinidad

Length 12–14½ in
(30–37 cm)

Tail 4¼–6 in
(10.5–15 cm)

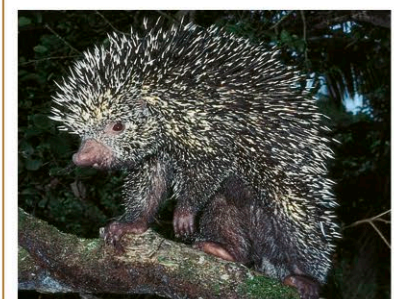
Weight 11 lb
(5 kg)

Social unit Individual

Status Least concern



This large, muscular porcupine climbs slowly but surely with curved claws, naked-soled feet, and prehensile tail, which is almost as long as the head and body and lacks fur toward the tip. By day, it sleeps in a hole, in a tree trunk, or in the ground. At dusk, the stump-tailed porcupine forages for leaves, bark, fruit, and shoots, and occasionally small animals.



spines intermingled with ordinary hairs

eyes set far back in rounded head

short, bristle-covered legs

SPINES AND WHISKERS

The back is covered by banded brown-black and white spines with white tips, intermingled with hairs. The nose has long, stout whiskers.